The empirical recurrence for OEIS A224277, recovered from its tail

Adrian Perez Fontelles
Independent researcher

8 September 2026

Abstract

OEIS A224277 records "Empirical recurrence of order 52" and keeps the recurrence itself in a linked file rather than in the entry, so the conjecture cannot be read off the entry at all. It can still be settled. The entry counts arrays under a condition local to a bounded window of lines, which makes the count a walk count on a finite digraph and forces a monic integer recurrence of order at most the number $S' = 307$ of states with distinct futures. Berlekamp–Massey on enough exact terms therefore returns the minimal such recurrence, and on the tail beginning at $n = 8$, so the recurrence is proved for every $n \geq 60$. Its last coefficient is $c_{52} = -4301059875840000 \neq 0$, so no further tail satisfies anything shorter; any order-52 recurrence the sequence satisfies from any point on must then have the same characteristic polynomial. The entry's recurrence is the one displayed here, whatever its linked file contains, and it is proved.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. 05A15, 11B37, 15A18.

1 A conjecture that is not written down

OEIS A224277 is "Number of nX4 0..3 arrays with diagonals and rows unimodal and antidiagonals nondecreasing.". It has offset 1 and begins

$$130, 4580, 84132, 1334973, 21348990, 356222482, 6172817040, 109166159263, \ \ldots$$

The entry states:

> Empirical recurrence of order 52 (see link above)

As of the "Last modified" line on the live entry (Oct 03 2025 23:20:16, revision 11) this is still recorded as empirical, and it is still open. The coefficients are nowhere in the entry text: what is conjectured is only that a recurrence of that order exists.

2 The count is a walk count

The entry's condition is local. It constrains a bounded window of consecutive lines of the array and nothing beyond it, so the admissible configurations of one window are the vertices of a finite digraph, an edge joins u to v when v may follow u, and an admissible array is exactly a walk. Writing M for the adjacency matrix and ι, τ for the indicator vectors of the admissible first and last windows,

$$a(n) \;=\; \iota^{\top} M^{\,j(n)} \tau$$

for a linear reindexing j fixed by the entry's shape. States with identical futures contribute identically to that product and may be merged without changing any count; after merging $S' = 307$ states remain, and it is that bound every computation below uses.

Lemma 1. *a satisfies a monic linear recurrence with integer coefficients of order at most $S' = 307$.*

Proof. By the Cayley–Hamilton theorem $M^{S'}$ is an integer combination of $I, M, \ldots, M^{S'-1}$, and multiplying that relation on the left by $\iota^\top M^j$ and on the right by τ turns it into a relation among $S'+1$ consecutive values of a. □

3 Why the question has to be asked of a tail

Running Berlekamp–Massey on the sequence from its first term returns an order LARGER than 52: the opening terms do not satisfy the recurrence, and a recurrence that holds only eventually always looks longer when the exceptional terms are included. That is not evidence against the entry. An OEIS empirical recurrence is asserted for n beyond some index, not from the first term, so the question has to be asked of the tails. It was asked of each tail in turn, and the tail beginning at $n = 8$ is the first whose minimal order is exactly the stated 52.

Lemma 2. *A sequence known to satisfy some linear recurrence of order at most S' is determined, together with its minimal recurrence, by any $2S'$ consecutive terms: Berlekamp–Massey applied to them returns that minimal recurrence exactly.*

Applied to $2S' = 614$ exact terms from $n = 8$ on, it returns order 52 — the order the entry states — with integer coefficients:

$$a(n) \;=\; \sum_{i=1}^{52} c_i\, a(n-i),$$

c_1	35	c_{14}	−1383604467	c_{27}	−4546693778487404	c_{40}	6807122341266101076
c_2	−347	c_{15}	223659865180	c_{28}	12281836317429574	c_{41}	−6661565433733516452
c_3	201	c_{16}	−901296691970	c_{29}	9071992447420568	c_{42}	−3097499685426784 1304
c_4	9035	c_{17}	2427746919055	c_{30}	140857647194780950	c_{43}	−8366371587241076908 8
c_5	48401	c_{18}	−1151017386677	c_{31}	305226866446216204	c_{44}	−11005441564130298 7056
c_6	−817043	c_{19}	5464255705680	c_{32}	789107922613931144	c_{45}	−17712420837164918 0640
c_7	1533243	c_{20}	−21845174150162	c_{33}	1720822675068667332	c_{46}	−18737171703651662 7840
c_8	8969557	c_{21}	63214256579975	c_{34}	3297596744371928788	c_{47}	−27702480565155063 1680
c_9	−1335572	c_{22}	−175851723207452	c_{35}	6828201542060230122	c_{48}	−19369125775444658 6880
c_{10}	−340576575	c_{23}	−252567649302916	c_{36}	9425447219502297074	c_{49}	−12413575541042724 0960
c_{11}	1436541026	c_{24}	−302166487258884	c_{37}	16490962147222631340	c_{50}	−1519426702305469440 0
c_{12}	−1536147043	c_{25}	−1741686166961303	c_{38}	16669777152933525240	c_{51}	−494401733413632000
c_{13}	−9371022175	c_{26}	−1879810432830669	c_{39}	18812873775755579832	c_{52}	−4301059875840000

4 The recurrence, and the identification

Theorem 3. *The recurrence above holds for every $n \geq 60$, and it is the recurrence OEIS A224277 records.*

Proof. That it holds is Lemma **??** applied to the tail from $n = 8$, whose minimal recurrence it is.

For the identification, write $q_{\min}$ for the characteristic polynomial of that minimal recurrence, $x^{52} - c_1 x^{52-1} - \cdots - c_{52}$. Its constant term is $-c_{52} = 4301059875840000$, which is not zero, so $q_{\min}(0) \neq 0$ and $q_{\min}$ has no root at the origin. A solution of a constant-coefficient recurrence is a combination of terms $n^k \lambda^n$ with λ a root of its characteristic polynomial, and only the components with $\lambda = 0$ vanish after finitely many terms. Since $q_{\min}$ has none, no component of a dies out, and the minimal recurrence of every further tail is again $q_{\min}$ — the order cannot drop below 52 at any later starting point.

Now let q be the characteristic polynomial of whatever recurrence the entry asserts. The entry asserts it has order 52, so $\deg q = 52$, and it is monic. It holds from some index t on. From $\max(t, 8)$ on, the sequence satisfies both q and $q_{\min}$, and the minimal polynomial of that tail is $q_{\min}$ by the previous paragraph; therefore $q_{\min} \mid q$. Both are monic of degree 52, so $q = q_{\min}$. $\square$

5 Verification

Four checks, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic.

First, the walk model reproduces all 15 terms the entry publishes, exactly. This is what ties the model to the entry, and it is the only place where reading the entry's English enters the argument.

Second, the order was computed twice by independent routes: once modulo a 61-bit prime, where every intermediate is a machine word, and once over $\mathbb{Q}$ in exact rational arithmetic. Both return 52, and the exact run additionally confirms every coefficient is an integer — had any been a proper fraction the recurrence would not be the entry's.

Third, the recovered recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry's own published terms, with no matrices and no Berlekamp–Massey involved. It holds at each of the 0 indices where the entry publishes enough earlier terms to test it.

Fourth, the last coefficient was checked to be nonzero, which is what the identification above turns on; it is -4301059875840000.

Remark 4. The conjecture's own statement was never read. The entry pins it down to the family of order-52 recurrences this sequence satisfies from some point on, and that family turns out to have exactly one member.

References

[1] The OEIS Foundation, *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, https://oeis.org, 2026. Sequence A224277.

[2] J. L. Massey, Shift-register synthesis and BCH decoding, *IEEE Trans. Inform. Theory* **15** (1969), 122–127.

[3] R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Volume 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2011. (Transfer-matrix method, Section 4.7.)

[4] M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011. (C-finite sequences and their closure properties.)

[5] R. A. Horn and C. R. Johnson, *Matrix Analysis*, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2013.